Champion Swimmer Archie Goodburn to Carry the Match Ball Before 60,000 Fans

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A champion swimmer is about to have one of the biggest moments of his life and it won't be in a pool. Archie Goodburn, a 25-year-old swimmer from Edinburgh, will deliver the match ball for Scotland's rugby game against Australia at Murrayfield stadium next month, in front of more than 60,000 fans.

Goodburn is the Scottish record holder for the 50-metre **breaststroke** and a European bronze **medallist**. But his story is about much more than swimming. In 2024, he was diagnosed with a rare brain **tumour**. After surgery, he fought his way back into competitive swimming and he also started **campaigning** so that other people with brain cancer can get better treatment and more research. In recent weeks he has taken that campaign to Prime Minister Andy Burnham and to Scotland's First Minister, John Swinney.

Before swimming took over, Goodburn played rugby as a **blindside flanker** at school, so carrying the ball onto the pitch at Murrayfield in his home city is a perfect fit. "This means the absolute world to me," he said. The biggest crowd he has ever performed for was 10,000 people at the Edinburgh Military Tattoo, where he sang a solo of "What a Wonderful World" at age 12. This time the audience will be six times bigger.

The match takes place on Sunday, November 15, and supporters at the stadium will be able to donate to two charities, Brain **Tumour** Research and the Astro Brain **Tumour** Fund. Goodburn believes moments like this can help: "Things are beginning to move and this kind of initiative can make a difference."

Word Treasure

breaststroke -- Breaststroke is a swimming stroke swum on your front with both arms moving together.

medallist -- A medallist is a person who has won a medal in a competition.

tumour -- A tumour is an abnormal growth in the body that can make a person seriously ill.

campaigning -- Campaigning means working publicly to persuade people in power to make a change.

blindside flanker -- A blindside flanker is a rugby position on the side of the scrum the ball carrier cannot easily see.

Background you need

Delivering the match ball is a ceremonial honour in rugby, where a special guest carries the ball onto the pitch before the game begins.

Murrayfield is Scotland's home rugby stadium in Edinburgh, so a Scottish athlete can be honoured there in front of a home crowd.

Goodburn's main swimming event is the 50-metre breaststroke, a short sprint race swum on the front.

Charities raise money to study illnesses and improve treatment, which is why a public moment at a big match can help a campaign reach many people.

Break it down

LEAD: A champion swimmer will deliver the rugby match ball at Murrayfield
KEY EVENT: Scotland play Australia in front of more than 60,000 fans
+- WHO: Archie Goodburn, 25, from Edinburgh
+- WHEN: Sunday, November 15
EVIDENCE: He holds the Scottish 50-metre breaststroke record and returned to racing after brain tumour surgery in 2024
OPEN QUESTION: How much attention and how many donations will this moment bring to his campaign?

Why it matters

Goodburn's appearance links a major sporting event to health research, showing how one public moment can bring attention and donations to brain tumour treatment. It also shows an athlete rebuilding his career after serious illness.

Test what you remember

1. Who will deliver the match ball at Murrayfield?

(A) Andy Burnham
(B) Archie Goodburn
(C) An Australian rugby player
(D) John Swinney

2. What swimming record does Goodburn hold?

(A) The Scottish record for the 100-metre freestyle
(B) A world record set at age 12
(C) The European record for the 50-metre breaststroke
(D) The Scottish record for the 50-metre breaststroke

3. In what year was Goodburn diagnosed with a rare brain tumour?

(A) 2015
(B) 2026
(C) 1966
(D) 2024

4. Which rugby position did Goodburn play at school?

(A) Team captain
(B) Scrum-half
(C) Blindside flanker
(D) Goalkeeper

5. How large will the crowd be, compared with the biggest crowd he has performed for before?

(A) About the same size
(B) Twice as big
(C) Ten times bigger
(D) Six times bigger

6. Which two charities can supporters at the stadium donate to?

(A) Brain Tumour Research and the Astro Brain Tumour Fund
(B) A local swimming club and a rugby fund
(C) The Edinburgh Military Tattoo and a cancer fund
(D) Brain Tumour Research only

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: D 4: C 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Archie Goodburn: He said carrying the ball means the absolute world to him, and he believes things are beginning to move and this kind of initiative can make a difference.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):